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THE ARRIVAL OF THE RAILWAYS

A Danav, Agni Rath, Time Travel and What Not

A RAKSHAS

The sight of the first locomotive and its run led to hysteria amidst the local population. No one was sure what it was—a devil, a machine, a magical animal or some wizard that would capture their land. People hid from it, saw glimpses of it and floated stories about it. Some brave people ventured out to view and touch it. At Hooghly, a businessman flogged his horse to achieve the speed of steam trains. At another place near the Bombay railway line, there were rumours circulated that you needed to sacrifice life to power trains and the steam run required a corpse per kilometre!

In 1852, in Bombay, work on the construction of embankments to build the line was at an advanced stage and, as Faviell and Fowler, the contractors, struggled to finish it, a steam locomotive landed at the port. It drew huge crowds and was named after the sitting Governor of Bombay, Lord Viscount Falkland. Though stationary steam machines and steam ships had been in regular use, it was the first time the people of Bombay were seeing a moving steam apparatus on rails.

Used for shunting operations, ‘Lord Falkland’ created euphoria. Its hissing, puffing and whistling, its smoke, soot and smell, and its sheer size and weight were awe-inspiring. From the ports, it was pulled down a public road by more than 200 coolies for its first operation. While it scared a few, it struck a chord with most others.

The engine’s shunting operations began near Byculla from a grove belonging to a landlord named William Phipps. The grove, which had been